

A PLOTBREW WRITING WORKBOOK

THE ROMANTASY WORLDBUILDING WORKBOOK



Build worlds worth falling in love in.

What This Is

This is a worldbuilding workbook designed specifically for romantasy — fantasy romance where the world isn't just backdrop, but an active force shaping and pressuring the love story.

In romantasy, worldbuilding isn't separate from romance. The political marriage that forces enemies together, the magical bond that connects two people against their will, the ancient feud that makes love forbidden, the class divide that seems impossible to cross — these aren't setting details. They're the engine of your story.

This workbook helps you build worlds that create romantic tension by design.

Who This Is For

This workbook is for writers who want to:

- Build fantasy worlds that feel real and internally consistent
- Create external obstacles that pressure and test relationships
- Understand how geography, politics, magic, culture, and history can generate romantic conflict
- Move beyond generic fantasy settings to worlds that could only produce *your* story
- Develop worldbuilding that readers will want to live in

Whether you're writing your first romantasy or your tenth, whether you're a plotter who needs everything mapped before drafting or a pantsier who discovers your world as you go — this workbook meets you where you are.

How This Workbook Is Structured

Each section follows a two-part structure:

Part One: The Foundation

This is the worldbuilding itself — how your geography, magic, government, religion, economy, culture, or history actually works. These elements exist in your world regardless of your characters' romantic situation.

Strong foundations make your world feel real. Readers can tell when a world has depth versus when it's cardboard scenery hastily assembled behind the love story.

Part Two: [Topic] & Romance

This is where worldbuilding becomes romantic tension. Each section shows you how to mine its topic for obstacles, intimacy, stakes, and conflict specific to love stories.

A magic system isn't just about what spells exist — it's about what happens when one character is vastly more powerful than the other, or when a magical bond forces intimacy neither chose, or when using power for someone you love costs something real.

REMEMBER

You need both parts. A romance between a servant and a prince needs a believable class system (foundation) that actually creates stakes and obstacles for their relationship (romance application). Skip the foundation and your world feels thin. Skip the romance application and you're not using your world to its full potential.

How to Use This Workbook

You Don't Have to Do Everything

This workbook is comprehensive — intentionally so. Not every section will apply to your story. Not every question will be relevant.

Skip freely. If your story doesn't involve inter-species romance, skip that section. If religion isn't a factor, move past it. If your characters aren't part of an institution, those questions aren't for you.

The goal isn't to fill every blank. The goal is to build what your specific story needs.

You Don't Have to Go in Order

The sections are numbered for reference, not because you must complete them sequentially.

Some writers start with magic because that's the heart of their world. Others start with the political situation that creates their central conflict. Some build geography first because place shapes everything else.

Start wherever you have the most energy or the clearest vision. Let that section inform the others.

Focus on What Creates Stakes

As you work through each section, keep asking: **How does this create obstacles for my characters?**

Not every piece of worldbuilding needs to directly pressure the romance — some details just make the world feel real. But if you find yourself developing elaborate systems that never touch your love story, you might be worldbuilding for worldbuilding's sake rather than story's sake.

The best romantasy worldbuilding does double duty: it makes the world feel real *and* it makes the romance feel impossible (until it isn't).

Use the Integration Checks

At the end of each section, you'll find Integration Checks — questions that connect that section's topic to others. These are important.

Worlds feel real when their systems interact. A magic system affects government (who has power). Religion shapes culture (what's taboo). History explains current politics (why the feud exists). Geography determines economy (who controls resources).

If each section exists in isolation, your world will feel like a collection of unrelated details. Integration Checks help you weave everything together.

Examples Are Guides, Not Rules

Throughout this workbook, you'll find examples drawn from popular romantasy novels — ACOTAR, Fourth Wing, From Blood and Ash, Serpent & Dove, and others. These show what good answers look like and what level of specificity is useful.

But these examples aren't templates to copy. Your world should be *yours*. Use the examples to understand the kind of thinking these questions invite, then develop answers that serve your unique story.

A Note on Tropes

Romantasy is a trope-heavy genre, and that's not a weakness — it's a feature. Readers come to romantasy *wanting* enemies-to-lovers, forced proximity, forbidden love, fated mates, morally grey love interests, and "there's only one bed."

This workbook doesn't shy away from tropes. Instead, it helps you execute them well.

The difference between a tired trope and a beloved one isn't the trope itself — it's the execution. An enemies-to-lovers romance where the enmity is shallow and easily overcome is boring. An enemies-to-lovers romance where both characters have genuine, legitimate reasons to hate each other — where choosing love means betraying everything they believed — that's compelling.

CORE PRINCIPLE

■ *Worldbuilding is how you make tropes feel earned.*

The forced proximity isn't just "they're stuck together" — it's the specific institution, geography, political situation, or magical bond that makes escape impossible.

The forbidden love isn't just "they're not supposed to be together" — it's the specific laws, cultural taboos, religious strictures, or historical enmity that makes their love dangerous.

Build your world to support your tropes, and your tropes will sing.

Before You Begin

You don't need to know your whole story before starting. Many writers discover their plots through worldbuilding — realizing that the magic system they developed creates a perfect obstacle, or that the political situation they built suggests an ending they hadn't considered.

Let the worldbuilding work *with* your story, not as a separate task you complete before writing.

And remember: worldbuilding exists to serve the story. A beautifully detailed world that doesn't create stakes for your characters is just a setting guide. A sparse world that perfectly pressures your romance is doing its job.

Build what you need. Skip what you don't. Make a world worth falling in love in.

The Sections

SECTION	TOPIC	WHAT IT COVERS
1	Geography & Environment	Physical world, climate, travel, how place creates obstacles
2	Flora, Fauna & Ecosystems	Plants, animals, bonded creatures, inter-species romance
3	Culture, Customs & Daily Life	Social norms, taboos, courtship, what's forbidden
4	Economy, Labor & Resources	Wealth, class, debt, what money means for love
5	Government, Power & Law	Politics, law, forbidden relationships, enemies-to-lovers
6	Religion, Myth & Prophecy	Faith, vows, divine purpose, what the gods demand
7	History & Lore	The past that haunts the present, inherited conflict
8	Magic System	How magic works, magical bonds, power dynamics

Additional Sections (9–21) cover specialized topics: technology, time & calendar, language, magic conflicts, pressure cooker settings, institutions, and more.

Appendix A: Revealing Worldbuilding in Prose — A practical guide to deploying your worldbuilding in scenes without info-dumps.

Let's Begin

Turn to whichever section calls to you first. There's no wrong starting point.

Your world is waiting to be built.

SECTION ONE

GEOGRAPHY & ENVIRONMENT

Geography isn't just a map — it's the physical constraints that shape everything else. Mountains create borders that become political divisions. Deserts isolate cultures. Rivers determine where cities grow. Control of fertile valleys determines who holds power.

This section is divided into two parts:

Part One: The Foundation — The physical reality of your world. Terrain, climate, resources, dangers, and how geography shapes where and how people live. This is the geographic baseline that exists regardless of your characters' romantic situation.

Part Two: Geography & Romance — How physical geography creates romantic tension. Separation and proximity, dangerous journeys together, entering each other's worlds, places that hold emotional meaning.

You need both.

A Note Before You Begin

Not every question in this workbook will apply to your story — and that's completely fine. Skip what doesn't fit.

Worldbuild for its own sake if you want. A richly developed world has value beyond what appears on the page. Use the "romance connection" prompts for brainstorming if they're helpful, or leave them blank if that element is just background texture.

Come back later. If you're not sure whether something matters yet, skip it and return once your story has taken more shape.

This workbook is a tool, not a test.

How to Think About Geography in Romantasy

Geography in romantasy works like a pressure system. The physical world can compress your characters together, force them apart, or create conditions where they have no choice but to rely on each other.

Before you draw a map, ask yourself: What geographic situation does my romance need? Not every hill and river needs to serve the plot, and that's okay. But the geography you choose to emphasise should be doing something. Think about the locations where your

scenes happen, the terrain your characters travel through, and the distances between them.

Background geography creates atmosphere and believability. Foreground geography creates story.

The Geography-as-Friction Framework

A useful way to think about your world's geography is to develop it around friction. This could be friction between your characters, or between what they want and what they can have.

Separation Friction

What physical obstacles keep them apart?

- Different kingdoms separated by mountains
- An ocean that takes months to cross
- A magical barrier that can only be crossed under certain conditions
- War zones that make travel deadly

Proximity Friction

What forces them together despite themselves?

- A snowed-in mountain pass
- A ship voyage with no escape
- An isolated estate or academy
- A dangerous journey requiring partnership

Resource Friction

What geographic scarcity creates conflict?

- Water rights in a desert region
- The only pass through the mountains
- A rare magical resource found in contested territory
- Trade routes that require cooperation between enemies

Geography that doesn't create friction isn't wasted. It's just setting.

The “Pressure Cooker” Principle

Some of the most effective romantasy settings work as pressure cookers. These are environments that trap characters together and force interaction. The key is that leaving must be impossible, dangerous, or carry consequences they're not willing to accept.

When characters can't escape each other, they're forced to confront conflict instead of avoiding it, rely on each other despite distrust, and share space long enough for attraction to build beneath their defences.

Here are some ways you can make the container seal tight:

- **Physical trapping:** Islands, academies, sieges, ships, and remote estates. These are locations with literal boundaries characters can't cross.
- **Circumstantial trapping:** Dangerous wilderness requiring partnership, diplomatic missions, and shared exile. In these situations, separating means failure or death.
- **Environmental trapping:** Storms, seasons, and magical barriers that prevent departure. These are external forces that make leaving impossible regardless of desire.
- **Social/political trapping:** Arranged marriages, hostage situations, and court obligations. In these circumstances, leaving would destroy reputation, alliance, or lives.

The pressure cooker works because proximity breeds intimacy. Characters see each other at their worst. They can't keep up facades. Small moments accumulate. Shared meals, overheard conversations, accidental touches in tight quarters. The setting does half the work of bringing them together.

The Key Question

If your characters could simply walk away from each other, would they? If yes, your geography might need to make walking away impossible, dangerous, or costly.

Common Geographic Patterns in Romantasy

Settings That Force Proximity

SETTING TYPE	WHY IT WORKS	EXAMPLES
The Academy/Training Ground	Characters live, train, and compete in close quarters with no escape	<i>Fourth Wing, Zodiac Academy</i>

SETTING TYPE	WHY IT WORKS	EXAMPLES
The Isolated Estate	Limited cast, limited space, limited options for avoidance	Gothic romances, <i>Pride and Prejudice</i> variations
The Ship/Caravan	Moving container with enforced proximity and shared danger	Pirate romance, trade caravan stories
The Siege/War Camp	External threat forces cooperation; death is the alternative	Military romantasy
The Diplomatic Mission	Enemies must travel together, represent opposing sides	Arranged marriage journeys
The Wilderness Journey	Survival requires partnership; dangers reveal character	Quest narratives

Geographic Barriers That Create Stakes

BARRIER TYPE	ROMANTIC FUNCTION	STORY POSSIBILITIES
Mountain ranges	Separate nations/cultures; make travel seasonal	Characters from opposite sides; winter trapping
Oceans	Create complete separation; make departure permanent	Letters across distance; the weight of leaving

BARRIER TYPE	ROMANTIC FUNCTION	STORY POSSIBILITIES
Deserts	Isolate cultures; make resources precious	Oasis politics; survival journeys
Magical borders	Can be crossed only by certain people or under certain conditions	One character can cross, one cannot
War zones	Make travel deadly; create no-man's-land between peoples	Enemies from opposing sides
Political borders	Crossing means treason or exile	Forbidden love across enemy lines

Environmental Conditions That Affect Romance

CONDITION	HOW IT CREATES PRESSURE	ROMANTIC BEATS IT ENABLES
Harsh winters	Traps characters indoors; requires shared warmth	Forced proximity; "snowed in" scenarios
Dangerous nights	Characters must shelter together after dark	Shared watch; protective sleeping arrangements
Seasonal access	Passes close, ships can't sail, travel becomes impossible	Racing against time; trapped until spring

CONDITION	HOW IT CREATES PRESSURE	ROMANTIC BEATS IT ENABLES
Resource scarcity	Sharing becomes necessary; generosity becomes meaningful	Sharing food/water; sacrifice for the other
Magical weather	Unpredictable; can trap or separate without warning	Sudden proximity; unexpected separation

Common Mistakes with Geographic Worldbuilding

Mistake #1: The Teleporting World

Characters travel vast distances with no sense of time passing. A journey that should take weeks happens between chapters with no mention of how they traveled or what dangers they faced. Distance has no weight. Separation has no stakes. Reunion carries no emotional punch.

FIX

Establish travel times and stick to them. The journey itself can be where the romance happens.

Mistake #2: The Convenient Geography

Geographic features appear or disappear based on plot needs. A mountain range exists when you need to separate characters but vanishes when they need to reunite. Readers notice. Stakes that feel fake are stakes that don't matter.

FIX

Establish your geography early and let it constrain you. Let the physical world create problems you didn't plan for — those problems often generate the best scenes.

Mistake #3: The Empty Map

You have a map with named places, but none feel lived-in. The geography exists but doesn't affect anything. Geography should create culture, which creates characters, which creates conflict. If your geography doesn't explain why people are the way they are, your world is just a painted backdrop.

FIX

For every major geographic feature, ask: *How does this shape the people who live here?* Let geography explain cultural difference, which explains why your characters see the world differently.

Mistake #4: The Consequence-Free Environment

Your world has dangerous regions and deadly terrain — but no one suffers consequences from them. Characters trek through the Deadly Wastes and emerge fine. If danger is all threat and no delivery, readers stop believing in it. And if readers don't believe the world is dangerous, they don't believe your characters need each other to survive it.

FIX

Let the environment actually hurt people. Show us the consequences — exhaustion, injury, loss. Make survival meaningful.

Mistake #5: Geography Without Emotional Resonance

You describe the setting in detail, but it's all physical — mountains are tall, forests are dense, cities are crowded. None of it connects to how your characters feel. Setting should be emotional landscape. The place where they first met should feel different than other places. The character's homeland should feel like *home*.

FIX

Give each major location an emotional quality, and let characters experience it differently. The same castle might feel like prison to one character and sanctuary to another.

Reference: Travel Times (Fantasy Approximations)

MODE OF TRAVEL	DISTANCE PER DAY	NOTES
Walking (easy terrain)	15-20 miles	Healthy adult, good weather
Walking (difficult terrain)	8-12 miles	Mountains, forest, desert
Horseback (sustainable)	25-35 miles	Without exhausting the horse
Horseback (hard riding)	50-60 miles	Cannot maintain long-term
Changing horses (relay)	100+ miles	Requires infrastructure

MODE OF TRAVEL	DISTANCE PER DAY	NOTES
Ship (sailing)	100-150 miles	Dependent on wind and current
Carriage/wagon	20-30 miles	Roads required; slower on rough terrain

Part One — The Foundation

The Big Picture: Your World's Scale

Geography is the skeleton of your world. Before you name a single kingdom or draw a single border, it helps to know how big the stage is. As such, there's a significant difference in terms of setting a romantic story that spans an entire continent and one confined to a single city with walls. The distances between characters, the cost of travel, and the possibility of escape or reunion are all shaped by scale.

Try to let geography do emotional work, too. Distance isn't just miles. It's the ache of separation, the danger of the journey, and the question of whether reunion is even possible. A mountain range between two lovers is a different kind of obstacle than a locked door, but both force the same question: how far will you go?

A good starting point is to ground your world's scale in what your characters can see, walk, and survive. If your protagonist has never left her village, the next town over might as well be another planet.

What's the geographic scope of your story?

Check the scope that best fits your story, then note the primary locations where your romance actually takes place. Even epic-scale worlds usually focus on a handful of key locations.

SCOPE	✓	PRIMARY LOCATION(S)
Single city/location (isolated island, palace, academy)		
Single region (kingdom, province, territory)		
Multiple regions (nations, continents)		
Entire world (epic scope)		
Multiple worlds/realms (parallel dimensions, portals)		

If your world is large, where specifically does your romance happen?

You don't need to detail everything — just locations that matter.

LOCATION TYPE	NAME/DESCRIPTION
Primary location	
Secondary location	
Secondary location	

Naming Places

Place names do a surprising amount of worldbuilding work. A name like “Ashenmere” tells readers something different than “Goldport” before you’ve described either place. The right names make your world feel cohesive and grounded, even if readers can’t quite explain why.

In the real world, most place names started out as descriptions. They told people what was there (a river, a hill, a forest), who lived there, or what happened there. Over time, languages shifted and the meanings got buried. That’s why we don’t think of “Oxford” as “the place where oxen ford the river” even though that’s exactly what it means.

You can use this same logic when naming locations in your world. Think about who named the place and what mattered to them. A farming settlement might be named for the land. A fortress might be named for the family who built it. A holy site might carry the name of a god. If your world has multiple cultures or languages, places might have

different names depending on who's talking about them, which is a small detail that can add a lot of texture.

Finding Your World's Naming Patterns

If you want your place names to feel like they belong to a specific culture or language family, a bit of research goes a long way:

- Pick a real-world language that matches the sound you're going for. Look up common place name elements in that language. What prefixes and suffixes keep appearing? What sounds feel characteristic?
- Study how real names are built. Most are compounds. A word for a landscape feature (river, hill, field) combined with a descriptor (colour, size, a person's name). Once you spot the pattern, you can build your own.
- Behindthename.com has a useful place names section if you want to browse etymologies for inspiration.
- Keep it pronounceable. If your reader stumbles every time they hit a place name, it pulls them out of the story. Read your names aloud. If you can't say it comfortably, your reader won't be able to either.

Don't feel pressured to make every name meaningful, though. Sometimes a name just needs to sound right for the world. If the etymology is enriching your story, great. If it's slowing you down, move on and come back to it later.

Kingdoms & Nations Overview

If your world has multiple kingdoms or nations, this table can help you keep track of them at a glance.

You don't need to fill in every field. Just jot down what you know right now. Maybe you only have a name and a climate so far, and that's perfectly fine. You can always come back later as your story takes shape.

Terrain Types

Not every terrain in your world needs equal development. Your world might include mountains, forests, deserts, plains, wetlands, coastlines, islands, rivers, tundra, or even magical and unusual terrain. That said, consider focusing on the two or three that actually matter for your story. These are the ones your characters traverse, fight over, or call home.

TERRAIN	EXISTS?	WHERE?	WHAT IT PROVIDES	WHAT CHALLENGES IT CREATES
Mountains				
Forests				
Deserts				
Plains/ Grasslands				
Wetlands/ Swamps				

TERRAIN	EXISTS?	WHERE?	WHAT IT PROVIDES	WHAT CHALLENGES IT CREATES
Tundra/Ice				
Coastline/ Beaches				
Islands				
Rivers/Lakes				
Volcanic regions				
Magical/ unusual terrain				

Which 2-3 terrains matter most for your story?

Most stories don't use every terrain equally. Identify your priority terrains — the ones worth developing because your characters interact with them directly.

PRIORITY	TERRAIN	WHY IT MATTERS TO YOUR STORY
1		
2		
3		

Resources & Territorial Control

Who controls the land is what determines who gets what, and therefore, who has the most power. Fertile land, fresh water, mineral deposits, and trade routes are all things worth fighting over, worth marrying for, and worth dying for.

Resource control has great potential in romantasy because it could be used to create an imbalance of power between the love interest(s) and drive the inciting conflict between them. It's also a believable way to explain arranged marriages, political alliances, or economic pressures that force characters into impossible choices.

Rather than explaining resource conflict through exposition, try showing it through what characters can and can't do. For example, a character from a region with limited water availability may cringe while watching someone run their bathtub. Someone

from contested territory might notice strategic value in a landscape that others see as beautiful. You can let resource awareness emerge through small reactions, casual comments about price or scarcity, and the background hum of what everyone in this world worries about.

When two characters come from opposite sides of a resource conflict, the tension often shows itself in what they assume about each other, what they're careful not to say, and the moments when privilege becomes visible.

Real-World Inspiration

Resources have always shaped conflict. Oil drives wars and political alliances. Water rights spark disputes between nations sharing rivers. Spices once fuelled colonial expansion. Salt was taxed so heavily it caused revolutions. Diamonds fund civil wars. Rare earth minerals create modern tech dependencies.

What resource in your world holds this kind of power?

What natural resources are geographically concentrated?

RESOURCE	WHERE IT'S FOUND	WHO CONTROLS IT
Fertile farmland		
Fresh water		
Timber/forests		
Mineral deposits		
Coastal access/ports		
Mountain passes		
Magical resources		

What geographic features give strategic or economic advantage?

The only pass through the mountains? The river that enables trade? The natural harbor? The defensible high ground?

FEATURE	LOCATION	WHO CONTROLS IT	HOW THEY GOT CONTROL

What geographic resource creates tension or conflict in your world?

Water rights? Arable land? Access to the sea? Control of a trade route?

YOUR ANSWER

How does geographic resource control affect your characters?

Does one character's family/nation control something the other's needs? Is there territorial dispute between their peoples? Does geography explain the power imbalance between them?

YOUR ANSWER

Describing Your Setting

Geography isn't just about what's there. It's about what it feels like to be there. Think of a first kiss scene: if it occurs in a garden full of blooming jasmine, it will feel different from a first kiss that happens in a stone corridor with a torch-smoke odour. Readers should be able to feel the grit of sand, the dampness of a cave, the sweltering heat of a forge.

One of the most powerful elements you can utilise is filtering sensory detail through your POV character's emotional state. A person who is in love notices the warmth of sunlight, the sweetness of blossoms, and the softness of grass. That same garden, to a grieving character, might feel too bright, the flowers cloying, the birdsong intrusive. Of course, you shouldn't describe every tiny detail. We've all tried reading a book where every tiny detail was painstakingly descriptive to the point you didn't even know what the point of the scene was. To prevent this, I'd choose two or three sensory details for each scene that reinforce the atmosphere you are trying to create.

It also helps to avoid the "weather report" opening, where a scene begins with a neutral description of the setting. Instead, try integrating sensory details into action and emotion. Rather than writing "The room was cold," you could write something like "She pulled her cloak tighter, breath misting in the unheated chamber." When your character interacts with the environment, it reveals both setting and feeling at the same time.

What does your primary setting look, sound, smell, and feel like?

SENSE	DESCRIPTION
What you see	
What you hear	
What you smell	
What the air feels like (temperature, humidity, wind)	

How does the environment change at different times of day?

TIME	DESCRIPTION
Morning	
Midday	
Evening	
Night	

What's beautiful about this place?

The moments of wonder, the views that take your breath away:

YOUR ANSWER

What's harsh or uncomfortable about this place?

The grit, the difficulty, what wears on people:

YOUR ANSWER

How does the environment affect mood?

Does the setting feel oppressive? Peaceful? Wild? Claustrophobic? Expansive?

YOUR ANSWER

Climate, Weather & Seasons

Weather creates immediate physical conditions that affect what's possible, from travel and agriculture to warfare and daily life. Seasons are particularly great at pushing your story forward. For example, they can create deadlines (e.g., they have to get married by the first spring shower), waiting periods (people are stuck together until spring thaws the roads), or markers of time passing in a slow-burn romance.

A good rule to remember is that seasons are a great indirect way to show time passing. Conversely, you can use weather to create immediate physical danger or discomfort. Make your character sopping wet, or so cold they have no other option BUT to cuddle with their love interest. Oh the things we'll put our protagonists through!

Seasons can mirror emotional shifts, too. A relationship that thaws as winter ends, tension that builds with summer heat, a reckoning that arrives with autumn.

What's the overall climate?

YOUR ANSWER

What seasons exist and how distinct are they?

YOUR ANSWER

What season is your story set in?

The season affects what's possible — travel, festivals, danger, comfort.

ASPECT	DETAILS
Season	
What this season makes possible	
What this season makes impossible	

How do seasons affect life in your world?

What activities are only possible in certain seasons? What becomes impossible?

SEASON	WHAT'S POSSIBLE	WHAT'S IMPOSSIBLE
Summer/warm season		
Winter/cold season		
Transitional seasons		

Do seasons have cultural or economic significance?

Planting and harvest? Festival seasons? Trading seasons when passes are clear? Raiding seasons?

YOUR ANSWER

Does the season create pressure or opportunity in your story?

Racing against winter? Waiting for spring thaw? Only able to travel in summer?

YOUR ANSWER

Weather Events

Weather can serve your romance in unexpected ways. A storm that forces two characters to shelter together. A blizzard that delays a departure just long enough. A fog that provides cover for a secret meeting.

Extreme weather raises stakes — characters surviving a dangerous storm together, the vulnerability of being cold or wet or frightened. These moments accelerate emotional intimacy.

What extreme weather occurs in your world?

Blizzards? Monsoons? Dust storms? Magical weather?

YOUR ANSWER

What's the worst weather can get?

YOUR ANSWER

How do people prepare for and survive extreme weather?

YOUR ANSWER

Does extreme weather play a role in your story?

What happens, and how does it affect your characters' plans or situation?

YOUR ANSWER

Light and Darkness

When the sun rises and sets affects what's possible — travel, work, danger, rest.

Light and darkness shape romantic opportunity. Darkness provides privacy, cover for secret meetings, the intimacy of being the only two people awake. Daylight is for public performance; nighttime is when masks come off.

In worlds where darkness brings genuine danger — creatures that hunt at night, magic that activates after sundown, cold that kills — characters may be forced into close quarters after dark. Shared watches, sleeping in proximity for safety: these are romance accelerants.

How many hours of daylight exist in your setting?

Does this vary by season? Is there magical darkness or eternal light anywhere?

YOUR ANSWER

When is it safe to travel or work, and when is it dangerous?

Are there creatures that hunt at night? Magical dangers after dark? Cold that kills?

YOUR ANSWER

What do people typically do after dark?

When travel stops, when work ends — how do people spend evenings?

YOUR ANSWER

Shelter & Survival

When the environment is hostile, shelter becomes essential.

Shelter is intimacy compressed. When characters must share limited space — a cave, a single room at an inn, a tent — they lose the ability to maintain distance. They see each other in vulnerable moments: sleeping, waking, sick, injured, afraid.

The quality of shelter matters. A luxurious inn is a different romantic setting than a damp cave. One offers comfort that might lower defenses; the other offers hardship that bonds through shared suffering. Scarcity of shelter raises stakes further — if there's only one safe place, and your characters must share it with enemies or strangers, conflict multiplies.

What shelter options exist in your world's wilderness?

SHELTER TYPE	WHAT'S AVAILABLE
Natural (caves, overhangs, dense forest)	
Constructed (inns, waypoints, abandoned buildings)	
Improvised (what travelers carry or build)	

What happens when shelter is scarce or contested?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there a moment in your story when shelter becomes critical?

ASPECT	DETAILS
The situation	
What shelter they find	
What this situation reveals or creates	

Dangerous Regions

Every world has places that are deadly, and therefore avoided, or crossed only with preparation and company. Danger can add to the romance of the journey in several ways though because it can raise stakes and force partnership. Survival requires cooperation. Cooperation requires trust. And trust requires vulnerability.

The most common mistake with dangerous regions is telling readers it's deadly without actually showing it. Characters warn that "no one survives the Thornwood," yet your protagonists stroll through unscathed. To make the danger feel real, you have to show the consequences. Let someone in your party get gravely ill or injured because someone made a bad judgement call. When your characters emerge on the other side, they should be changed. Exhausted, wounded, and closer than before. The journey through danger is where walls come down.

What regions are dangerous or forbidden?

REGION	WHAT MAKES IT DANGEROUS	WHO GOES THERE ANYWAY (AND WHY)

What specific dangers exist in wild or unsettled areas?

DANGER TYPE	SPECIFICS
Environmental	
Creatures	
Magical	
Human threats (bandits, hostile groups)	

Do your characters travel through dangerous territory?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Where and why	
What dangers they face	

Borders & Boundaries

Borders are boundaries, and boundaries create conflict. Every border in your world is a line that someone drew or that nature carved, and every line comes with rules about who can cross it and what it costs when they do.

In romantasy, borders serve as obstacles at their most fundamental level. A river between warring kingdoms means your characters were never supposed to meet. A magical barrier means every stolen moment on the wrong side carries real consequences. A closed mountain road means if your characters choose one another then they will both be exiled.

What geographic features create borders?

Mountain ranges? Rivers? Oceans? Magical barriers? Deserts?

YOUR ANSWER

How permeable are these borders?

Easy to cross? Heavily guarded? Physically impassable? Seasonally accessible?

YOUR ANSWER

Do your characters come from opposite sides of a significant border?

ASPECT	DETAILS
What separates them	
What crossing means (legally, socially, personally)	

Displacement & Refugees

Geography creates not just borders but displacement — people driven from their land by war, disaster, or conquest.

Are there displaced peoples in your world?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Who was displaced	
From where	
Why (war, disaster, persecution, environmental collapse)	
Where they went	

How are refugees and displaced people treated?

Welcomed? Tolerated? Exploited? Persecuted?

YOUR ANSWER

Is either of your characters displaced, a refugee, or descended from displaced people?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Which character	
What was lost	
What they carry from their homeland (objects, memories, traditions)	
Do they hope to return? Is return possible?	

How does displacement affect their identity and relationships?

YOUR ANSWER

Part Two — Geography & Romance

Home & Belonging

Geography isn't just about land; it's also about emotion. The concept of home has to be one of the most emotionally laden ideas in romance. A character may travel away from home to find love, or have to choose between the person they love and returning home. They may find that no matter where they are, home is always where the other person is, or they may discover that choosing this person means being exiled from all that is familiar. Instead of simply stating a location is important to your character, try to show home through sensory details. What do your characters reach for when they are feeling homesick? What scent immediately takes them back? When writing scenes set in a character's home territory, allow them to move easily and comfortably throughout the space. They should know which floorboards creak, which windows stick. Then compare this to how they move through unfamiliar spaces; hesitantly, cautiously, slightly off-balance.

The conflict between "where I am meant to be" and "where love is leading me" creates some of romance's greatest emotional moments. A character deciding to remain in their lover's world, or asking their lover to come into their own world, is a declaration of equal significance as any verbal confession of love.

Where does your protagonist feel at home?

The place that shaped them, where they feel most themselves:

YOUR ANSWER

What does home look, smell, sound like to them?

The sensory details that mean “home”:

YOUR ANSWER

Where does your love interest feel at home?

YOUR ANSWER

What does home mean to them — sensory details?

YOUR ANSWER

Where does each character feel like an outsider?

CHARACTER	WHERE THEY FEEL ALIEN
Protagonist	
Love interest	

Do they ever discuss or share what home means to them?

YOUR ANSWER

Entering Each Other's Worlds

If your main characters are from different places, then travelling to visit each other is important; there's a special vulnerability in inviting someone into your home. Your own world becomes visible to you through the visitor's eyes; you begin to notice again what you have been ignoring, including the beauty as well as the flaws.

When a character enters their love interest's world, try filtering every observation through their outsider perspective. What confuses them? What impresses them? What makes them uncomfortable? Their reactions can reveal both the world and the character at once.

The “native” character, meanwhile, experiences a different kind of vulnerability. Suddenly, they’re aware of poverty they’ve normalised, privilege they never thought about, or customs that seemed perfectly reasonable until someone else explained them out loud.

Write the small moments. The love interest automatically reaching to help with something the visitor doesn’t know how to do. The visitor mispronouncing a word everyone here knows. The native defending their home against a criticism they privately agree with. These fish-out-of-water scenes create closeness because they need explanations, patience, and the courage to look silly in front of someone you care about.

Does one character visit the other’s home territory?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Who visits whose world	

What’s the sensory experience of entering unfamiliar territory?

What do they notice first? What’s strange? What’s beautiful? What’s uncomfortable?

YOUR ANSWER

*How does the “native” character see their home differently through the visitor’s eyes?
Pride? Shame? New appreciation? Defensiveness?*

YOUR ANSWER

*How does the visitor respond to this new environment?
Curiosity? Discomfort? Unexpected delight? Judgment?*

YOUR ANSWER

What does the visitor understand about their partner after seeing where they come from?

YOUR ANSWER

Travel & Distance

Distance creates stakes. If your characters can teleport anywhere, separation carries no weight, but if journeys take weeks on horseback, every departure matters and every reunion is earned.

Travel also forces shared vulnerability in ways that daily life doesn't. There's something about tending each other's blisters, sharing warmth on a cold night, and having nowhere to retreat to that bonds people faster than months of safe, comfortable interaction. And when your characters are apart, you can make that distance felt through the details: letters that arrive too late, the agony of not knowing whether someone is safe, and the slow stretch of days without word.

How do people typically travel?

On foot? Horseback? Ships? Flying creatures? Magical transportation?

YOUR ANSWER

How long does travel take between key locations?

ROUTE	TRAVEL TIME
From capital to border	
From one character's home to the other's	
Across the dangerous region	

What makes travel difficult or dangerous?

YOUR ANSWER

Does magic affect travel?

If teleportation or fast travel exists, who has access? What limits it? Why don't people use it for everything?

YOUR ANSWER

Do your characters undertake a significant journey?

ASPECT	DETAILS
From where to where	
How long	
What happens during the journey	

Isolated Locations

Forcing characters to share a space will help to drive their relationship forward faster than if they were able to come and go as they please. The more opportunities your characters are given to get away from one another, the longer it will take for them to

have to confront the fact that they need to communicate or compromise. Isolated settings force confrontation, require cooperation, and create the kind of pressure that transforms reluctant attraction into something undeniable.

It helps to establish early on why leaving isn't an option, and to make that reason feel real and insurmountable. In *A Court of Mist and Fury*, the bargain Feyre struck Under the Mountain means she owes Rhysand a week of her time each month. She has no way out; she can't get to him earlier than agreed. This is what writers call "forced proximity", and it's an amazing way to make characters share a space.

As a result, you can plan ahead to utilise the confines of the space to your advantage. Consider what rooms are used most by all of the characters, how small the hallways are, and what common resources (food, water, etc.) will require collaboration. Also, be sure to write the sense of confinement and the developing intimacy together. Even though characters may find themselves attracted to one another, many times they will still feel trapped or resentful of being forced to live in such close proximity to one another.

Have fun with this plot device and find interesting ways to use the setting to make your characters interact! On a ship, there's nowhere to go after an argument, so you're eating breakfast together whether you like it or not. At an academy, the professor keeps pairing them for sparring practice. In a snowed-in estate, someone has to share a bed because the guest wing is freezing. The setting should be generating its own little problems. Let it do some of the storytelling work for you.

Also, remember that when characters have the ability to leave and instead choose to remain, their decision is a statement.

What isolated locations exist?

Islands, remote estates, mountain fortresses, ships at sea, academies, pocket dimensions:

LOCATION	TYPE	WHY PEOPLE GO	WHY LEAVING IS DIFFICULT

Do your characters spend time in an isolated location?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Which location	
Why they're there	
How long	
Who else is present	

What does isolation create — pressure, intimacy, conflict, or revelation?

YOUR ANSWER

Sacred & Significant Locations

Some places carry meaning beyond geography — battlefields, temples, places where history happened.

What locations are sacred or historically significant?

LOCATION	WHY IT'S SIGNIFICANT	WHO CONTROLS IT

Do your characters visit a significant location?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Which one	
Why they go	
What happens there	

Does geography hold memory in your world?

Do battlefields feel haunted? Do sacred groves hold power? Does land remember?

YOUR ANSWER

Cities & Settlements

What major settlements exist?

SETTLEMENT	SIZE/TYPE	KNOWN FOR	WHY IT'S LOCATED HERE (GEOGRAPHIC ADVANTAGE)

Where do your characters spend most of their time?

CHARACTER	PRIMARY LOCATION
Protagonist	
Love interest	

Does urban vs. rural matter for your characters?

Different worldviews? Different comfort zones? Class associations?

YOUR ANSWER

Magical Geography

Does magic create or alter geography?

Floating islands? Magically sustained forests? Regions where magic fails? Portals? Blighted lands?

YOUR ANSWER

Are there regions where magic is stronger or weaker?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Where magic is strong (and why)	
Where magic is weak (and why)	

How does magical geography affect your characters?

Does one lose power in certain places? Must they travel to a magical location? Are there places they can't go?

YOUR ANSWER

Places with Meaning

The environment in which your characters live can help to reinforce their feelings or act as an obstacle to them. A love scene in a sunny field will have a totally different effect than one in a crumbling building. A confession in a storm has a much greater impact than one made in complete silence.

You can do this intentionally. Set the mood for your characters' emotions by using sunny weather for happy moments and storms for confrontational moments, or do the opposite. A kiss in a dangerous situation has urgency, while a kiss in a serene garden appears to be an intentional choice.

Pathetic fallacy (when the environment takes on the characteristics of a character) can be helpful when used sparingly. A storm during a fight scene, or the sun breaking through the clouds as two people are making amends. These add to the scene without yelling "SYMBOLISM" at the reader.

You can also illustrate how your characters view the world based on their emotional state. Someone who is in love sees beauty in everything. Someone who is grieving looks at the exact same landscape and sees nothing but desolation. It's a simple aspect of storytelling, but it accomplishes a great deal.

Furthermore, give your characters "their place." A location that becomes special to the relationship, possibly where they first met, had their first kiss, or survived something terrible together. When the characters return to that place later in the story, you don't need to explain why it's significant. The reader should already feel it. A line like "She hadn't returned to the bridge since that night" can be very powerful, but only if you've established that connection earlier.

What's the emotional quality of your primary setting?

Does it feel oppressive, expansive, peaceful, threatening, beautiful, decaying?

YOUR ANSWER

Does the environment shift over the course of your story?

Do characters move from one type of landscape to another? Does the same place feel different as circumstances change?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there a location that becomes meaningful to your characters specifically?

A place they return to, a place where something changed, a place that's "theirs":

YOUR ANSWER

Integration Check

QUESTION	ANSWER	EXAMPLE (ACOTAR)
How does geography explain cultural differences (from Section 3)?		Each Court's territory shapes its people: Spring Court's eternal bloom creates beauty-
How does geography create or reinforce power structures (from Section 5)?		focused culture; Night Court's untamed and starry forests create a more feral society
How does geography interact with magic (from Part 1)?		Between fae and human domains — Spring magic is growth and renewal; Night magic is
What geographic resource or territory is contested in your world?		the moon and stars. Beyond the walls, outside one's territory to conquer them; some fae
		want to protect them; humans just want to survive

Quick Reference: Geographic Stakes

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD	EXAMPLE (ACOTAR-STYLE)
Key location 1		<i>The Spring Court manor — a grand estate surrounded by gardens, where Feyre is both</i>
Key location 2		<i>captive and the magical barrier separating the mortal lands from faerie</i>
Key location 3		<i>Under the Mountain — Amarantha's dark court, site of climactic confrontation</i>
Key location 4		<i>The mortal village — Feyre's impoverished home, what she left behind</i>
Key location 5		<i>The Night Court — a place of stars and darkness, initially frightening, later</i>
The contested resource or territory		<i>the seven High Lord territories, each controlling different types of magic and land</i>

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD	EXAMPLE (ACOTAR-STYLE)
The barrier separating peoples or characters		<i>The Wall prevents humans from entering faerie (without consequence) and</i>
The dangerous region		keeps fae from crossing <i>south of trials, corruption, and enslavement</i>
The isolated location		<i>The Spring Court manor — Feyre is the only human, can't leave, surrounded by fae</i>
The significant journey (from → to)		<i>Mortal lands → Spring Court (captivity) → Under the Mountain (trial) → Night Court</i>
The place that matters emotionally		(the transformation) <i>gallery — where Feyre finds purpose and connection through painting</i>

Final Thought: Geography Is Story Made Physical

Your map isn't just where things are — it's why characters must make the choices they make. The mountain range is why two nations distrust each other. The desert is why whoever controls the oasis controls the trade route.

Build geography that explains your world and creates the situations your story needs.